

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

Below is an extract from a newspaper article about updated rules of table manners:

How to behave at the dining table nowadays: Rules of table manners

Do you like eating with your fingers? It may have been frowned upon for decades but eating with your hands in a restaurant is now acceptable (e.g. for pizza), so long as you do not lick your fingers clean afterwards! In our more informal times, a new ten-point guide to acceptable modern dining behaviour and manners has been released.

Top tips include cutting food into manageable pieces before picking it up, using a napkin to wipe messy hands and using a fork to pick up any food that spills onto the plate. It even reassures people that it is acceptable to use cutlery like knives and forks, even if fellow diners choose not to. Many traditional rules remain, such as sitting up straight, keeping elbows off the table, and waiting for food to cool instead of blowing on it. 'Table manners are no longer about sticking to a strict and outdated code of conduct. They exist for guidance but shouldn't take away from the pleasure of sharing a meal,' experts say.

Below are four new rules:

1. Never use your mobile phone at the table. Definitely no texting!
2. Never wipe your mouth with your hand or talk with your mouth full.
3. If eating with hands, take small bites so you don't spill anything.
4. If you are using a napkin, place it on your lap. Don't tuck it into your shirt.

For your school's Mind Your Manners Week, your group has been selected to conduct a workshop on dining and table manners. Discuss with your group what to include in this workshop. You may want to talk about:

- some kinds of behaviour that might be considered rude at the dining table
- some traditional rules and updated rules on dining manners
- which rule is the most important one and why
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you watch TV while you are having dinner?
2. Do you prefer to use chopsticks, or a knife and fork?
3. Do you use your mobile phone at the dining table?
4. Do you think table manners are important?
5. Should table manners be taught in school?
6. How do you feel about people using their mobile phones at the dining table?
7. Are there any cultural differences between Western and Asian table manners?
8. How closely should people follow the rules of table manners?